
The Public And Life-Assurance

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other hand, maintains that 150 are "very much too many" for aggregation in a single hospital (qu. 5348); and he and Sir E. Currie, and Dr. Gayton, agree in the safety and advantage of sending all but the very worst cases, even long distances (if necessary), by water. The belief of the last-named gentleman as to the superiority of the results of treatment on the floating, as compared with the shore, hospital, should also be allowed much weight considering his large experience at Homerton and on board the *Atlas* respectively. Dr. Taylor further states that "the expenses to be incurred, apart from those of the doctor, nurses, and all the requirements of the hospital management, would be considerable." The Royal Commission report: "Floating hospitals, on the other hand, have the advantage of comparative cheapness."

In view of the large amount of testimony in favour of floating hospitals, notwithstanding some drawbacks, it is to be hoped that the Liverpool sanitary authority will not lightly abandon the idea of employing hulks for the reception of small-pox cases.

THE PUBLIC AND LIFE-ASSURANCE.

THE national importance of life-assurance in its bearing upon the causes incidental to pauperism, cannot well be overrated, more especially if we bear in mind the intimate relations between pauperism and public health. There can be no question about the healthy effect upon life-assurance in England of the Act of 1870, which enacted that all life-assurance companies should render official annual reports to the Board of Trade. It now alone remains for the public to utilise the valuable information afforded by these official reports as a guide to the selection of a sound office in which the expenses of management are satisfactorily low. We have seen several attempts to render the information contained in these reports readily available for the public, and one of the most successful of those attempts is that compiled and published by Mr. William Bourne of Liverpool, an associate of the Institute of Actuaries; it is entitled "The Handy Assurance Guide." This guide gives, in a condensed and convenient form, the following important particulars relating to ninety-seven assurance offices. It gives the total amount of the life-fund, details of the last year's new business, the life premium-income, the expenses of management, and the percentage of the expenses to the premium-income. Excluding the Equitable (United States), the New York, and the Prudential, which is mainly an industrial office, the premium-income of the various companies ranged downwards from £682,351 in the Scottish Widows' Fund Office. As a guide to the selection of an office holding out the prospect of the best return for the premium paid, the percentage of expenses of management (including commission) to premium-income should not be lost sight of, and is infinitely more important to the insuring public than the rate of premium charged.

So long as but a small proportion of the premium is swallowed up in expenses of management, the rate of premium is comparatively unimportant. The percentage of expenses of management, even if industrial offices and new offices be included, shows a remarkably wide range. In the London Life Association, the percentage of expenses does not exceed 4.1, and the next lowest percentages are 5.6 in the Metropolitan, and 5.8 both in the Metropolitan and the Clergy Mutual. It is somewhat surprising to find that the percentage rises to 12.0 in the Mutual, and 14.1 in the Provident Clerks; in strictly mutual offices, we should, at any rate, expect to find a low percentage of expenses. These percentages are, however, low compared with the following: Reliance, 20.4; London and Lancashire, 22.5; British Equitable, 24.8; Whittington, 28.8; and Gresham, 29.0. The insuring public would do well fully to consider the true import of these valuable figures. There is one other fact in connection with assurance-offices which has an important bearing upon the returns that may be expected for life-premiums. This is the mean rate of interest realised from

the life-funds. In English offices, this may be taken to vary little from £4 per cent. In American and colonial offices, however, a much higher rate of interest is obtained; and, in the case of the two large American offices included in Mr. Bourne's list, although the proportion of expenses in each case exceeds twenty per cent., the effect of such a deduction is greatly, if not entirely, counteracted, as regards the return to the insured, by the high rate of interest earned by the invested life-fund.

DR. ACLAND, Regius Professor of Medicine in the University of Oxford, has been made a Companion of the Order of the Bath.

A VERDICT of wilful murder has been returned against Dr. Ford, at Ashton-under-Lyne, for causing the death of a servant-girl by an illegal operation.

MR. JAMES CANTLIE will deliver a lecture on Cholera before the Medical Society on Friday evening, the 26th instant, in the Board-room of Charing Cross Hospital, at eight o'clock. Visitors are invited to be present.

THE third annual dinner of the pupils of the Hygienic Laboratory attached to University College took place on Thursday, at the Grosvenor Gallery. Professor Corfield presided, and there was a large attendance of past and present pupils.

AT the Westminster Hospital Medical School, the Entrance Scholarship, of the value of £80, has been awarded to Mr. C. J. Lownds, and that of the value of £40 to Mr. F. R. P. Taylor and Mr. C. S. Vines, equal.

MR. E. PEARSE BURD, formerly District Auditor for North Lancashire, has been appointed Inspector of the Local Acts and Loans, an office rendered vacant by the appointment of Mr. Alfred D. Adrian to a post in the secretarial department of the Local Government Board.

WE publish this week a short notice of the first meeting of the Military Medical Society, which has been formed at Aldershot. We hope that other large stations may be induced to follow this excellent example. The utility of such societies among army medical men is apparent. The large amount of experience relative to the diseases incidental to the medical service is lost for want of some such association. The meetings of the present Society will be held monthly.

AT the South London District Branch meeting, which will be held on Wednesday evening next, in the Governors' Court Room, St. Thomas's Hospital, at half-past 8, Dr. Savage will read a paper on "The Gouldstone Murder, in its relation to the Plea of Insanity in Criminal Cases;" and Dr. Bristowe a paper on "Masked Cerebral Tuberculosis." The attendance of members of the Association is invited.

WE are requested to state that the Rev. Canon Barry, principal of King's College, London, will present a testimonial, which consists of an illuminated album containing an address and list of subscribers, together with a purse, to Professor Bentley, on the occasion of his retiring from the post of dean of the medical faculty. The presentation will take place on Wednesday afternoon, October 24th, at 4.30, in the large theatre of King's College.

DEATH FROM HYDROPHOBIA.

AN inquest was held this week on a little boy, two and a half years of age, who was bitten on the wrist by a strange dog, which ran in at the open house-door. The wound was cauterised, and the child